

Ghosts in the DARKNESS

Women connive with officials to declare their husbands dead for Rs 300 a month under the Widow Pension Scheme, cheating the government of crores of rupees

By Subhash Mishra |

Lilawati flaunts sindoor and a mangalsutra; she also fasts for her husband's longevity like any devout Hindu wife. Yet, there's a crucial difference: she declared her husband dead many years ago and is making a living out of it, getting Rs 300 every month from the state Government under the Vidhwa Pension Yojana (widow pension scheme). The 55-year-old "widow's" husband is "dead" in Government records so that Lilawati can get Rs 3,600 each year. And she's just one among thousands of "widows" who are milking the state Government every year as part of a widespread and organised embezzlement racket. Lilawati's husband Ramprasad is alive and, in fact, lives with her; he is only dead in the state administration's records, thanks to the racketeers.

Hundreds of such women in Lucknow alone are embezzling government funds by declaring themselves widows even while they live with their husbands. INDIA TODAY interviewed a number of such women like Ganga Devi, Munni Devi, Ram Kumari, Leela Bati and Geeta Devi, who are living with their spouses but are logged as widows in official records and are receiving the pensions. "This racket is not confined to the state capital Lucknow alone. Similar cases are being discovered in

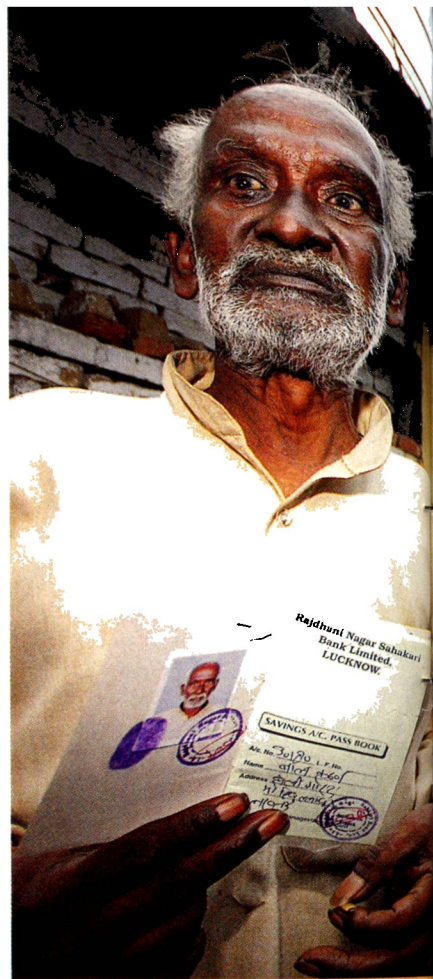
other parts of Uttar Pradesh. The scam could be worth crores of rupees," says a senior officer of the Social Welfare Department, which releases funds to district magistrates for welfare schemes, including the Old Age Pension Scheme and Widow Pension Scheme.

A fraud of this magnitude, espe-

Geeta Devi

is one of hundreds of women in Lucknow who have declared their husbands dead to avail of the Widow Pension Scheme

cially by those living below the poverty line, is not possible without the connivance of middlemen and officials. Just getting enrolled as a widow in Government books is a task in itself. First, a village pradhan or a city corporator identifies a deserving widow



living below the poverty line. Her name is then forwarded to the block office, which sends it to the district probation officer of the tehsil for final approval. The beneficiaries are then asked to open a bank account into which the money is transferred each